

Effectiveness of Women's Political Participation in Uganda

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Half of my life has been geographically distributed in three countries across two continents, each with its own distinct culture. Despite astronomical differences amongst these societies, the one thing I found to be homogenous is the toxic masculinity and rigid patriarchal structures that continue to exacerbate gender inequality in the community. As a female resident of any country in this world; it is impossible to be unaware of the injustices suffered by women, especially at the hands of men. Upon learning that my degree entails fieldwork in Uganda, only one thought intrigued me: to what extent did the phenomenon of gender inequality prevail in the east-African country of Uganda.

As of 2020, 50.7% of Uganda's population is female (World Bank, 2020). In 1990 the lower secondary educational attainment of women in Uganda was 6.2% (10% lower than that of men), this has risen to approximately 16% over two decades (half of that of men) (World Bank, 2021a; World Bank, 2021b). Additionally, 26.1% of women have been subjected to intimate partner violence, 34% are married before the age of 18, 14.6% of their time is spent on unpaid domestic care work (double that of men) and 38.5% of those employed live below the international poverty line (5% higher than men) (UNWomen). It is worthy of note here that these statistics do not provide a complete picture of the situation, as 57.4% of the data on women is missing in the case of Uganda (UNWomen).

The structural disadvantage women face in Uganda is clear from the stats, however, as a developmental economist what is of interest to me is not the existence of the phenomenon, but rather why such blatant inequalities continue to exist. In this regard, I believe a deeper

understanding of the political treatment of women will provide an insight into what is preventing the actualization of gender equality in Uganda. Therefore, this blog, based on my fieldwork interviews with relevant stakeholders as well as existing literature, explores the political treatment of women and gender issues in Uganda.

Effective Political Participation

It is commonly known in feminist literature that effective political participation of women is shaped by critical mass, i.e., political presence (Dahlerup, 2013). While critical mass differs depending on the political economy of the country, literature deems it must be at least 30% (Dahlerup, 2006; Karam & Lovenduski, 2005). Not achieving said critical mass hinders a political actor's ability to lobby for women's rights, dissipating any impact they could have had on creating gender-sensitive policies (Agarwal, 2010; Dahlerup, 2013). However, presence is just part of the story, true effectiveness is only achieved if present females have the power and ability to successfully lobby for gender equality/women's rights (Dahlerup, 2006).

In the case of Uganda, the proportion of women in politics has significantly increased since Museveni, the current president of Uganda, came to power. In 1997, 18% of seats in national parliament were held by women, in 2021 this figure has reached 34% (World Bank, 2021c). In local government, seats held by women in deliberative bodies is 45.7% (UNWomen). While these figures sound promising, the ground reality depicts a conflicting picture. During his rise to power, Museveni has time and again campaigned for the cause of women. However, Museveni's dedication to including women in politics had more to do with increasing his legitimacy amongst

people than truly endorsing gender equality (Arendt, 2018). Consequently, despite reaching critical mass in 2006, the political participation of women has been ineffective for the most part, with some short-lived pockets of effectiveness along the way (Adi, 2009; Arendt, 2018). Why female Ugandan politicians are unable to achieve effective participation can be ascribed to two factors: socio-cultural norms and political structures in the country.

The Curse of Patriarchy

How sociocultural norms shape the political effectiveness of women in politics can be understood through the interconnectedness of the public and domestic spheres which shape the political treatment of women. Specifically, the inferior position of women in the patriarchal family structure directly defines how they are treated in a political space (Adi, 2009; Tripp, 1998). The gender identity and role of women in such a structure create the convention that they lack competence in public/professional roles, an ideology that even gender parity in education has failed to disprove (Datzberger et al., 2018; Mushemeza, 2009). Consequently, women are not taken seriously in their political roles, diminishing their ability to shape gender-inclusive policies.

Furthermore, the unequal burden of unpaid domestic work shared by women hinders their ability to even participate in politics, let alone for it to be effective. This is largely attributed to the fact that regardless of a woman's active participation in paid work, it does not relieve her of unpaid domestic duties (Patricio & Motta, 2020). This makes it difficult for them to actively participate in or even attend council and parliamentary meetings (Tripp, 1998). The inability of men to take the role of women in politics seriously exacerbates the problem due to the failure to schedule

meetings considering the convenience of women (E. Kamigisha, personal communication, April 27, 2022; Mushemeza, 2009; Tripp, 1998).

The social norms that are reinforced through this patriarchal structure also shape the policies adopted by the government (Bagire et al., 2017). It is difficult to discuss the history of this problem in-depth but the political treatment of the rise in teenage pregnancies during covid-19 can help illustrate the issue. When discussing the impact of covid-19 on Uganda during the fieldwork interviews, the rise in teenage pregnancies seemed to be a common concern amongst interviewees. The country has seen a 28% rise in teenage pregnancies since the onset of Covid-19 (Ojulu, 2021; The Independent, 2021). Religion and cultural institutions have prevented the return of these girls to school, as they are believed to be “immoral and wasted”, and therefore can “taint the other pure girls” (W. Tumuhairwe, personal communication, April 25, 2022). Evidently, socio-cultural norms tend to hinder the adoption of gender-inclusive policies in Uganda (Burgess and Campbell, 2016). The Minister of Education circumvented the question when asked about the government's actions to support pregnant teenage girls. Although he sympathised with the girls suffering at the hands of powerful men, he claimed that the government was powerless against the cultural institutions of Uganda (M. Dennis, personal communication, April 25, 2022).

Politics of the gender problem

Another hindrance to women's effective political participation in Uganda is the autocratic nature of Museveni's regime. It prevents political factions/actors from advocating for anything that isn't aligned with the president's personal agenda (Arendt, 2018). In the centralized political

system of Uganda, it is challenging for women to lobby for their rights, especially since they earn their position through patronage networks (Goetz, 2002). That is, most of these women belong to affluent political families, therefore, they are used as pawns to lobby for their husbands' political views rather than their own (Goetz, 2003; Pankhurst, 2003). This further contributes to diminishing the legitimacy of women in politics and keeps gender-inclusive policies off the ruling coalition's agenda (Pankhurst, 2003). Not only does this strengthen discrimination against women, but it further marginalizes lower-class women who aren't well represented in the political sphere.

To me, the first indication of the inferior position of women in Ugandan politics was the fact that none of the political figures we interviewed were female. Of the three female interviewees we did have, one was a secondary school teacher and member of the teachers' trades union whilst the other two were representatives of CSOs. The political figures in their interviews attempted to remain 'politically correct' when discussing gender issues, however, their unapologetic disregard for women's issues came through loud and clear. It was impossible to get a clear answer from them regarding the actions their political factions have taken towards (fixing) gender equality. The questions were brushed off by mentioning a few micro-level policies and their importance in addressing gender equality, without any comments on outcomes. A few even mentioned the ministry of women, however, nobody was able to quantify anything the ministry had achieved.

Conclusion

I was unsure about what to reflect on in this blog, until my conversation with Miss Elizabeth (a lawyer from a Ugandan CSO called FIDA). When questioned about why she got

involved with her organisation, she discussed the discrimination she faced in her previous job at a private law firm. “It is difficult for women to grow in such male-dominant environments. I could sense that they were not going to take me seriously, so I decided to join FIDA to advocate for women” (E. Kamigisha, personal communication, April 27, 2022).

To me, she sounded like an educated and insightful professional, probably more so than anyone else I had interviewed. Why then had such a competent woman been forced to leave her dream job? A recurring theme in all the answers she provided was the fact that Uganda was lacking a legal framework and political structure that advocates for women. Naturally, I decided to explore why this was the case. What was stopping women from advocating for their rights?

Whether the answer to this question is patriarchy, socio-cultural norms or political agendas, the reflections in this essay are proof that we need to go beyond just creating awareness of prevalent gender inequalities. Rather, the only way out of this long and vicious cycle of injustice is an in-depth understanding of what has let this system sustain. If effective political participation of women is hindered by the perception that women are incompetent, radical change will only come about with a shift in this social image.

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